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DJIA 44176.65 ▼ 450.94 1.01% NASDAQ 19962.36 ▼ 0.5% STOXX 600 551.01 ▼ 0.2% 10-YR. TREAS. ▲ 9/32, yield 4.498% OIL \$72.57 ▲ \$0.32 GOLD \$2,940.00 ▲ \$20.60 EURO \$1.0503 YEN 149.63

What's News

Business & Finance

- ◆ **After a strong holiday** quarter, Walmart set 2026 fiscal-year revenue and profit targets below analysts' expectations, sending its stock down 6.5% and pushing the market down, as well. **A1**
- ◆ **The S&P 500 fell 0.4%** after ending Wednesday at its third record of 2025. The Dow and Nasdaq retreated 1% and 0.5%, respectively. **B1**
- ◆ **A group of leading** indicators gauging the strength of the U.S. economy weakened at the start of the year, reflecting an uncertain outlook at the start of Trump's term. **A2**
- ◆ **Alibaba's** artificial-intelligence strategy helped drive third-quarter revenue growth to its quickest pace since late 2023. **B1, B2**
- ◆ **A grand jury** investigating criminal misconduct at fintech firm Synapse, where customer funds went missing, questioned an executive who raised alarms before the company collapsed. **B1**
- ◆ **Major League Baseball** and ESPN are ending their media-rights partnership, a sign of how legacy TV's decline and streaming's rise are changing the way Americans watch sports. **B1**
- ◆ **Airbus said it** expects to deliver more planes to customers this year than in 2024, despite supply-chain snarls. **B2**
- ◆ **Mercedes-Benz will** cut jobs and shift some production from Germany to lower-cost countries, saying it expects earnings to fall significantly this year. **B3**
- ◆ **KKR secured a** majority stake in Fuji Soft and plans to take it private after rival Bain dropped out of a bidding war for the software company. **B4**

World-Wide

- ◆ **The Trump administration** is stepping up its push for Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelensky to hand mineral rights worth hundreds of billions of dollars to the U.S. **A1**
- ◆ **The IRS began to** terminate thousands of employees, disrupting the agency when tax season is in full swing. **A1**
- ◆ **Sen. Mitch McConnell** said he won't seek an eighth term after serving in the chamber since 1985 and leading Republicans there for 18 years. **A4**
- ◆ **The Senate confirmed** Kash Patel as FBI director, a marquee victory in Trump's effort to strike back at an agency he has long considered his nemesis. **A3**
- ◆ **Gov. Kathy Hochul** said she wouldn't remove New York City Mayor Eric Adams, but plans to pursue legislation that would limit his authority. **A3**
- ◆ **The Trump administration** is moving to terminate a set of protections for Haitian immigrants who came to the U.S. while Biden was in office. **A3**
- ◆ **Trump is making** plans to disband the governing board that oversees the U.S. Postal Service and absorb the agency into his administration. **A2**
- ◆ **Israel's military said** one of four coffins handed to Israel by Hamas as part of an exchange contained an unidentified body, not that of the mother of two young children Hamas said it would release. **A8**
- ◆ **Bombs detonated on** empty buses at two locations near Tel Aviv, in what Israeli police said they were investigating as a suspected terrorist attack. **A8**
- ◆ **Died: David Boren**, 83, former Oklahoma governor. **A4**

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Ukraine's President Volodymyr Zelensky met Thursday in Kyiv with retired Lt. Gen. Keith Kellogg, the Trump administration's envoy.

U.S. Doubles Down on Pushing Ukraine to Make Minerals Deal

Zelensky is told 'you really need to sign' onto this demand, according to account

The Trump administration is stepping up its push for President Volodymyr Zelensky of Ukraine to hand mineral

By James Marson, Alexander Ward and Alan Cullison

rights worth hundreds of billions of dollars to the U.S., after Zelensky's initial rejection of the demand fueled President

Trump's escalating broadsides against Ukraine's leader.

The White House called Zelensky's refusal to sign a deal it proposed and his criticism of Trump unacceptable, a day after Zelensky said Trump is living in a "disinformation" bubble and Trump countered by calling Zelensky a dictator.

"They need to tone it down and take a hard look and sign that deal," Trump's national security adviser Mike Waltz said Thursday on Fox News.

Zelensky has said he is open to a deal, but that it needs more work.

The U.S. demands were

first presented by Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent in Kyiv last week.

A U.S. Republican lawmaker who met with Zelensky on the sidelines of the Munich Security Conference last week described the Ukrainian leader's account of the interaction with Bessent.

Bessent pushed the paper across the table, demanding that Zelensky sign it, the Ukrainian president told the lawmaker. Zelensky took a quick look and said he would discuss it with his team. Bessent then pushed the paper closer to Zelensky.

"You really need to sign

this," the Treasury secretary said. Zelensky said he was told "people back in Washington" would be very upset if he didn't. The Ukrainian leader said he took the document but didn't commit to signing.

The Treasury Department didn't respond to a request for comment. A spokesman for Zelensky didn't respond to a request for comment, but an

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- ◆ **Allies' fears grow as U.S. tilts to Russia.....** A6
- ◆ **Trump's Ukraine comments blindsides GOP.....** A6
- ◆ **Russia's advance slows as U.S. kicks off talks.....** A7

Moscow's American Spy in Ukraine

A social conservative who idealized Russia, Daniel Martindale pedaled into a war zone

By Brett Forrest and Vera Bergengruen

As Russian troops poured across Ukraine's border in the opening hours of the February 2022 invasion, Daniel Martindale pedaled through Kyiv, weighted down with supplies—and a secret.

Riding a scavenged mountain bike, the red-bearded 31-year-old from Indiana was planning to offer his services to Russian troops on the front line.

At first, he didn't get far. Ukrainian security agents on high alert in Kyiv

detained the unusual visitor, letting him continue his ride east the next morning only after deciding he was no saboteur.

It was the beginning of a high-risk descent into espionage and betrayal for the self-described Christian missionary. The journey would land Martindale in Moscow after he worked undercover in eastern Ukraine for more than two years, secretly calling in Russian attacks on Ukrainian troops and border towns.

To Martindale, Russia symbolized

the traditional values that he believed his own country had forsaken. "I realized that I want to be in Russia if World War III starts," he said in an interview with The Wall Street Journal. "I did not want there to be any chance that I would be fighting on the wrong side."

While his actions may have been extreme, Martindale's view of Russia as a sanctuary from a Western world he believed had lost its way underscores a shift among some American ultracon-

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Walmart Warns Of Slower Growth In Sales

Retailer reports strong holiday quarter as a result of bargain hunters

By Sarah Nassauer

Eggs. Coffee. Gas. The prices Americans pay for many everyday items have been stubbornly high. And their search to find savings wherever they can has been surprisingly good for Walmart.

But company executives on Thursday set 2026 fiscal-year revenue and profit targets below analysts' expectations, sending its stock down 6.5% and pushing the market down, as well.

The Dow Jones Industrial Average fell 1%, or about 450 points, while the S&P 500 dropped 0.4% and the technology-heavy Nasdaq declined 0.5%. Shares in Target lost 2% and Costco fell 2.6%.

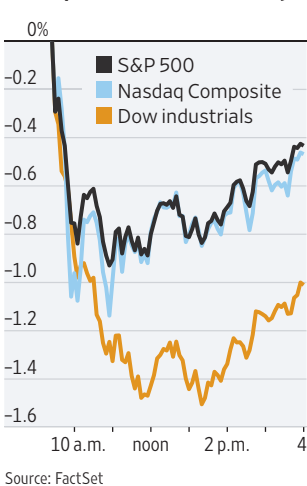
Walmart's forecast "raised another red flag just as mounting trade tensions threaten to drive up the cost of goods," said José Torres, senior economist at Interactive Brokers.

The discount retailer and country's biggest grocer—best known for its "everyday low prices" slogan—has been drawing in shoppers of all stripes amid high inflation. They have come to Walmart searching for its store-brand food, holiday toys and even to pick up weight-loss medicines at the pharmacy counter.

The dynamic boosted U.S. profit and sales at Walmart during the holiday quarter, including a 20% jump in its e-commerce business. The quarterly results—\$180.6 billion in revenue and \$7.9 billion in op-

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Index performance Thursday



Source: FactSet

◆ **Heard on the Street: Still bullish on Walmart** B10

When Null Is Your Name, Nothing Works

* * *

Computerese for 'no value' creates identity crisis

By Oyin Adegoyin

Nontra Yantaprasert couldn't wait to take her husband's shorter and easier-to-pronounce last name. She didn't know what kinds of problems it would cause.

His last name is Null, the same word used by computer scientists to mean "no value" or "invalid value." The Nulls of the world, it turns out, endure a lifetime of website bouncebacks, processing errors and declarations by customer-service representatives that their accounts don't exist.

After becoming a Null, she was due to travel to India in 2014 on a nonrefundable flight for a friend's marriage, but her visa hadn't arrived in the

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Canada Tops U.S. in Overtime



O CANADA: The Canadians defeated the U.S. 3-2 in the National Hockey League's '4 Nations Face-Off' final on Thursday night in Boston. Besides the U.S. and Canada, the tournament included teams from Finland and Sweden.

IRS Starts to Cut 6,000 Jobs, Risking Delays in Services

The Internal Revenue Service began to lay off thousands of employees Thursday as part of an initial plan to cut at least 6% of the workforce, a move that threatens longer customer-service wait times when tax season is in full swing.

By Brian Schwartz, Ashlea Ebeling and Katherine Long

A termination memo sent Thursday to IRS employees read: "Your continued employment at the Agency is not in the public interest." The email said employees would be removed from their positions on Thursday.

The agency is set to lay off at least 6,000 people from its roughly 100,000-strong workforce. Already, the IRS was struggling with recruitment and retention. The layoffs, which are mostly in the com-

pliance division, mean some collections and audits are likely to be paused, and one-on-one personal service is set to be more limited.

"Patience is going to be a virtue," said Tom O'Saben, director of government relations at the National Association of Tax Professionals. Still, most people who file electronically and choose direct deposit aren't likely to be affected.

The cuts aren't expected to include workers essential to the filing season. The administration also limited its deferred-resignation program at the IRS, telling workers involved in running the filing season that they couldn't stop working until May 15. More cuts could come after that date.

IRS employees were asked to come into the office Thursday and hand in government-issued equipment, agency ac-

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